perchance to sustain his political legacy well beyond that. Like a lot of regional parties, the JD(U) has not been particularly rich in a well-defined second line of leadership, and signs are that Nitish has found some time to attend to such thoughts in the autumn of his own political career.

On June 29, short of a month after the Lok Sabha results, at the JD(U) national executive meeting in Delhi, Nitish nominated his long-time confidant Sanjay Kumar Jha as the party's first working president. While Nitish remains the national president, the 56-year-old Rajya Sabha member will now steer the party organisation in the run-up to the upcoming assembly polls. Then, on July 9, the party inducted Manish Verma, a 2000 batch Odisha cadre IAS officer who had taken voluntary retirement in 2021 to work with Nitish. Verma, who turned 50 in April, has been appointed the party's national general secretary. He is the second IAS officer to join Nitish's party, after R.C.P. Singh who was Nitish's principal secretary before taking voluntary retirement to enter politics.

Before joining the JD(U), Verma served as an additional advisor to the CM and was a member of the Bihar State Disaster Management Authority. He had served in Odisha until 2012 when he opted for inter-cadre deputation to Bihar. There's strong speculation that the CM may even consider sending Verma to the Rajya Sabha and prepare him for future leadership roles in the party. The two new inductees at the top reveal, in their own ways, facets of Nitish's strategy. If Jha is credited with orchestrating the BJP-JD(U) reunion in January, Verma syncs with the CM's style of functioning on another front. The electrical engineer-turned-politician has always had a thing for professionalism and method. While the intricacies of caste politics are his forte, he is equally captivated by meticulously documented project reports, well-written notes, expertly crafted flow charts, and high-quality papers on development economics. That he's now giving a former bureaucrat a prominent position in a party full of career politicians could be seen as a natural corollary, even if an ironic one in a state as political as Bihar. It is not an irrelevant detail here that Verma, a Nalanda native, is from Nitish's Kurmi caste.

The strategic aim is, of course, to ensure his party's dominance in the next assembly election, due by October-November 2025. Nitish was known to be keen to have that preponed to this year so as to guarantee his own continued overlordship but the Lok Sabha results have changed the dynamics. The Modi government's reliance on the JD(U)'s 12 Lok Sabha MPs makes it unlikely that the BJP will seek to encroach aggressively on his political turf, as it was wont to earlier. The twin faces speak to both the desire for stability on that front as well as a keenness to retain a distinct, autonomous space. ■

THE TWO FACES REVEAL FACETS OF NITISH'S STRATEGY: JHA IS A NOD AT TIES WITH THE BJP, AND EX-IAS OFFICER VERMA, A KURMI, SYNCS WITH HIS WORK ETHIC



By Jumana Shah

When Gujarat's Disturbed Areas Act was legislated in 1986, the aim was to stop the distress sale of properties in areas that had witnessed communal violence. In fact, the Act's full name—the Gujarat Prohibition of Transfer of Immovable Property and Provision for Protection of Tenants from Eviction from Premises in Disturbed Areas Act—promised as much. But social observers and those in the know say, over the years, the Act is being used as a tool by those seeking to divide Gujarat on religious lines.

Take the Muslim woman in Vadodara whose case played out widely in the media. The 44-year-old single mother was allotted a flat under the CM Awas Yojana in 2018, in a lower-income group (LIG) society in the city. However, 33 of 462 residents of the society protested against the allotment, allegedly owing to her religion, claiming the allotment to be in violation of the Act. The protests, which first erupted in 2020, have prevented the woman from taking occupation of the flat even six years after the allotment. In a written complaint to the collector this June, the protesting residents cited possible "threat and nuisance due to her presence as she is the only Muslim allottee". While